Colossians 3:12–17 — Leader / Learner Guide

Service Manual for the Lord's Army · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: Because believers are chosen, holy, and beloved, they put on Christlike character bound by love and order their lives by the peace, word, and name of Christ, with thanksgiving.

Having told believers to put off the old clothes (3:5–9), Paul now gives the new wardrobe and a simple code of conduct for the new self.

- **The motive:** chosen of God, holy, beloved.
- **The dress code:** five virtues, forbearance, forgiveness, and love as the belt.
- **The code of conduct:** peace as umpire, the Word at home, everything in Jesus' name.

② Dressed for Service — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
3:12	*"chosen of God, holy and beloved, put on a heart of compassion …"*	Identity first; then the new wardrobe.
3:14	*"put on love, which is the perfect bond of unity"*	Love holds every other virtue in place.
3:16	*"Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you …"*	The Word-filled life parallels the Spirit-filled life (Eph. 5:18–21).

"Rule" (v.15): *brabeuō*, to act as umpire; related to "prize" in 2:18.

Thanksgiving three times: vv.15, 16, 17.

③ Teaching Flow

1. Why we wear it (3:12a) — Whose we are, what we are, why we are.

2. What we wear (3:12b) — Compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, patience.

3. How we wear it (3:13–14) — Bearing with, forgiving as the Lord forgave; love over all.

4. Peace and the Word (3:15–16) — Peace as umpire; the word of Christ dwelling richly in song.

5. The name (3:17) — Principles, not rule lists; all in Jesus' name with thanks.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **Textual variants:** v.15 NASB95 "peace of Christ" (NKJV "peace of God"); v.16 NASB95 "to God" (NKJV "to the Lord"). v.13 NASB95 "the Lord forgave" (some manuscripts "Christ").
- **Election (v.12):** keep the emphasis on encouragement; do not turn the class into a debate on predestination.
- **Peace as umpire:** not merely a subjective feeling; it works within God's revealed will.
- **Psalms, hymns, songs:** the distinctions are probable, not certain; avoid making rules about worship styles from them.

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Which piece of the new uniform in verse 12 do you most often leave in the closet?
2. How does "just as the Lord forgave you" change the way we forgive?
3. Compare 3:16–18 with Ephesians 5:18–21. What does the comparison teach?

Close: Next, the new self at home and at work: wives and husbands, children and fathers, servants and masters (3:18–4:1). "Put on love, which is the perfect bond of unity."

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